

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a local newspaper:

Hong Kong travel firm still offering wildlife experiences despite animal welfare pledge

Hong Kong-based travel firm Vapido is continuing to promote attractions that feature wild animal performances despite a new animal welfare policy enacted last month. The company defended its tours and said it was committed to helping "build a responsible tourism community and improve the lives of animals in the travel industry."

"Our approach is to continually work with operators to encourage long-term and sustainable change, which not only takes into consideration animal welfare but also communities who are directly impacted by the industry," a company spokesperson said. "We continue to work with our partners across the world to achieve this. One example is elephant tourism in Thailand, which comes with a cultural and religious heritage, and is beneficial for the local communities and the economy," she added.

Earlier this year, the travel company vowed to end ticketing for some animal attractions. Under its new policy, situations where wild animals are drugged or abused are banned. This ban extends to circuses and shows during which animals are forced to perform unnatural behaviour.

However, the animal welfare NGO, People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals, shared a video that showed dead bodies of horses and camels outside a tourist site in Egypt. While camel-riding activities in Egypt are listed as "currently unavailable" on Vapido's website, the company continues to offer camel rides in places including Dubai, Morocco, and Turkey.

You are a member of the Tourism and Travel Club at your school. Your group is giving a presentation to students about the effects of tourism on animals and local communities. You may want to talk about:

- types of tourist activities that involve animals
- how these activities may cause harm to animals
- possible benefits of these activities for animals and local communities
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Have you ever watched an animal show?
2. Do you enjoy animal shows?
3. Would you go on a camel ride?
4. How would you encourage people to treat animals better?
5. Do animals used in shows have a better life?
6. Why do people go to animal shows when on holiday?
7. Should all animal shows be banned?
8. What can the government do to increase tourists' awareness about animal welfare?